ween then PM Jawaharlal Nehru and Akali Dal chief Master Tara Singh, after which any state or central legislation that touched Sikh affairs had to be framed in consultation with key Sikh institutions. The Akal Takht listed about 10 amendments across five clauses of the Act, covering both terminological issues and penal provisions. It read the offending phrases as signs of a secular state encroaching upon panthic ground, besides being not insufficiently serious about religious infractions.

So far, the Mann government has given no public signal that it will keep the law in abeyance, as the Akal Takht instructed. But there was some compelling drama on show. What could have been a theoretical debate on sacrilege was imparted a live, demonstrative value with a disputed video that allegedly showed the chief minister in blasphemous acts. Branding it as authentic, the Akal Takht branded him "Guru Dokhi" and "Panth Virodhi"—a betrayer of the faith, in short. After a counter involving a forensic report didn't pass muster, Mann chose tactical submission.

Takeaways

- **Akal Takht wants Mann govt to amend 10 clauses in its anti-sacrilege law**
- **Its one-month deadline expires on July 29, but no firm action yet from Mann**
- **The tussle is key to who has sway over floating panthic constituency**

On June 29, Gargaj convened one of the more remarkable gatherings in Punjab's recent memory—the entire AAP dispensation, minus Mann, dutifully lined up to explain the law. "They had not even read the bill, even after it became law. Some of them are respected Sikh leaders. It was a bit surprising," Gargaj told INDIA TODAY later. But while it cooled temperatures with this show of obeisance, AAP parallelly tried to separate the acting jathedar from his institution, suggesting a disagreement with him need not mean defiance of religious authority.

In fact, it has questioned his very appointment, casting him as a nominee backed by Sukhbir Badal's Akali Dal. Cannily enough, this chimes with a demand from radical groups that a whole-community congregation known as Sarbat Khalsa should be convened to appoint the jathedar, as in earlier centuries, shedding the practice since 1925 of the Akali Dal being given a determinative role.

WHO SHOULD DECIDE?

On July 21, Mann said the state was consulting the Advocate General's office on the SGPC recommendations and will wait for its advice. Meanwhile, the Punjab assembly convenes for what should be a lively monsoon session on August 3.

This phase of combat is gentler in tone, but no less steely in intent—perhaps never before has anyone challenged the authority of the jathedar thus. Mann's departure for a vipassana retreat in Bengaluru as the deadline neared added another layer to the messaging. Perceptions will matter, with polls less than six months away. The law itself was an attempt by a Jatt Sikh CM to win panthic votes and it has by no means quit that pursuit. On July 22, a Punjab Police SIT was questioning Sukhbir about his role as home minister during the 2015 sacrilege incidents.

Speaking to INDIA TODAY, Gargaj avoided a combative tone, saying he trusted the Sikh ministers and MLAs who promised the law would be amended. "The assembly has time till July 29. We will cross that bridge when we come to it," he said. That bridge is now not too far. ■

▶ MAHARASHTRA

Sharad Power, a Teaser

Is the NCP (SCP) going to chum up with the BJP? Straws in the wind hint at negotiations—with Shinde as a crucial plot device

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

IT WOULD BE NOTHING SHORT OF AN AXIAL SHIFT in Maharashtra politics if it comes through. The Nationalist Congress Party (Sharadchandra Pawar), the rump group left by the split of the Ajit Pawar faction exactly three years ago, is now itself seen as veering closer to the ruling Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP). Not exactly through an NCP reunion—the idea floated by some after Ajit's demise. But through an independently growing proximity with other elements of the ruling coalition. Recent signs of warmth along those liaison lines have fuelled speculation about whether the party will back the renewed bid of the BJP-led National



Takeaways

- **Sharad Pawar, other top NCP (SCP) leaders drop hints of thaw with BJP**
- **Joining state, central govts part of likely deal; no reunion with Ajit faction**
- **Speculated precondition: elevating Fadnavis to post in Delhi; Shinde eyeing role**